



Current California Ocean Recreational Fishing Regulations - San Francisco Region

38°57.5 N. Latitude (Point Arena in Mendocino County) to 37°11 N. Latitude (Pigeon Point in San Mateo County)

Includes a portion of Mendocino County, the portions of Sonoma, Marin and San Francisco counties bordering the Pacific Ocean, and most of San Mateo County

Regulations for some species may differ inside San Francisco Bay; [view regulations applicable to San Francisco Bay](#).

This summary of current regulations was updated on **May 1, 2026**.

See [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for complete regulation information, including regulations for species not covered here.



Point Arena to Pigeon Point. Sport fishing regulations on this page may not apply within [San Francisco Bay](#). Note: Map shows [state marine protected areas](#). (click/tap to enlarge)

Open Fishing Seasons

● = Partially closed fishing season or alert

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Open Fishing Seasons

● Rockfish

Please see the [San Francisco Management Area Recreational Groundfish Regulations Summary table](#) for current rockfish recreational fishing regulations.

[Rockfish Identification Guides \(PDFs\)](#)

● Cabezon

Please see the [San Francisco Management Area Recreational Groundfish Regulations Summary table](#) for current [cabezon](#) recreational fishing regulations.

● Kelp Greenling, Rock Greenling

Please see the [San Francisco Management Area Recreational Groundfish Regulations Summary table](#) for current [kelp greenling](#) and [rock greenling](#) recreational fishing regulations.

● Lingcod

Please see the [San Francisco Management Area Recreational Groundfish Regulations Summary table](#) for current [lingcod](#) recreational fishing regulations.

● Leopard Shark

The recreational fishery for [leopard shark](#) (*Triakis semifasciata*) is **open year-round, at all depths**. The daily bag and possession limit is 3 fish with a minimum size limit of 36 inches total length. For complete regulation information, see current [ocean sport fishing regulations](#).

The leopard shark is part of a group of fish known as [groundfish](#), which includes over 90 species that live on or near the bottom of the ocean (with a few exceptions). [View additional groundfish information](#).

● Pacific Sanddab and Other Flatfish

The recreational fishery is **open year-round, at all depths** for the following species: [Pacific sanddab](#) (*Citharichthys sordidus*), [butter sole](#) (*Isopsetta isolepis*), [curlfin sole](#) (*Pleuronichthys decurrens*), [flathead sole](#) (*Hippoglossoides elassodon*), [rex sole \(PDF\)](#) (*Glyptocephalus zachirus*), [rock sole](#) (*Lepidopsetta bilineata*), and [sand sole](#) (*Psettichthys melanostictus*). Refer to [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for size limits, bag limits, and other regulations pertaining to these species.

Identification Guide: [Common Sport-Caught Flatfishes of Del Norte, Humboldt, and Mendocino Counties \(PDF\)](#)

Pacific sanddab and other flatfish are part of a group of fish known as [groundfish](#), which includes over 90 species that live on or near the bottom of the ocean (with a few exceptions).

[View additional groundfish information](#).

● Petrale Sole and Starry Flounder

The recreational fisheries for petrale sole (*Eopsetta jordani*) and [starry flounder](#) (*Platichthys stellatus*) are **open year-round, at all depths**. There are no bag or size limits for petrale sole or starry flounder. For complete regulation information, see current [ocean sport fishing regulations](#).

Identification Guide: [Common Sport-Caught Flatfishes of Del Norte, Humboldt, and Mendocino Counties \(PDF\)](#)

Petracle sole and starry flounder are part of a group of fish known as [groundfish](#), which includes over 90 species that live on or near the bottom of the ocean (with a few exceptions).

[View additional groundfish information.](#)

● California Scorpionfish (a.k.a. sculpin)

The recreational fishery for [California scorpionfish](#) (*Scorpaena guttata*) is **open year-round, at all depths**. The daily bag and possession limit is 5 fish with no minimum size limit. For complete regulation information, see current [ocean sport fishing regulations](#).

The California scorpionfish is part of a group of fish known as [groundfish](#), which includes over 90 species that live on or near the bottom of the ocean (with a few exceptions).

[View additional groundfish information.](#)

● Other Federally Managed Groundfish

The recreational fisheries for all other [federally managed groundfish](#) species ([soupfin shark](#), Dover sole, English sole, arrowtooth flounder, [spiny dogfish](#), skates, ratfish, grenadiers, finescale codling, Pacific cod, [Pacific whiting](#), [sablefish](#), and thornyheads) are **open year-round, at all depths**. Refer to [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for size limits, bag limits, and other regulations pertaining to these species.

The [groundfish](#) group includes over 90 species that live on or near the bottom of the ocean (with a few exceptions).

[View additional groundfish information.](#)

● Pacific Halibut

The recreational fishery for [Pacific halibut](#) (*Hippoglossus stenolepis*) is open as of April 1, 2026. South of Point Arena, the season will continue through December 31, 2026 or until the quota is reached, whichever is earlier.

The daily bag and possession limit for Pacific halibut is one fish, with no minimum size limit. When angling, no more than **one line with two hooks attached may be used**. For complete regulation information, see current [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#). For further information about Pacific halibut, please visit the CDFW [Pacific Halibut web page](#).

Identification Guide: [Common Sport-Caught Flatfishes of Del Norte, Humboldt, and Mendocino Counties](#) (PDF)

● California Halibut

The recreational fishery for [California halibut](#) (*Paralichthys californicus*) remains open year-round. The daily bag and total possession limit is two fish north of Point Sur, Monterey County. The minimum size limit is 22 inches total length.

Identification Guide: [Common Sport-Caught Flatfishes of Del Norte, Humboldt, and Mendocino Counties](#) (PDF)

● Sharks (State-managed)

Open year-round, except that [white sharks](#) (*Carcharodon carcharias*) may not be taken or possessed at any time. The bag limits for [sixgill shark](#) (YouTube) (*Hexanchus griseus*) and [broadnose sevengill shark](#) (*Notorynchus cepedianus*) allow take of one fish per day with no size limit. The bag limits for [shortfin mako shark](#) (*Isurus oxyrinchus*), [common thresher shark](#) (*Alopias vulpinus*), and [blue shark](#) (*Prionace glauca*) allow take of two fish per day with no size limit.

● Surfperch

The recreational fishery for [surfperch](#) (PDF) (family Embiotocidae) is open year-round. The daily bag and possession limit is 20 fish in combination of all species (except shiner perch), with not more than 10 fish of any one species. [Shiner perch](#) (*Cymatogaster aggregata*) have a separate bag and possession limit of 20 fish. [Redtail surfperch](#) (*Amphistichus rhodotus*) have a minimum size limit of 10½ inches total length.

[View surfperch regulations for inside San Francisco Bay.](#)

Identification Guide: [Common Surfperches of California](#) (PDF)

● White Seabass

The recreational fishery for [white seabass](#) (*Atractoscion nobilis*) remains open year-round. The daily bag and possession limit is three fish. The minimum size limit is 28 inches total length or 20 inches alternate length.

● Sturgeon

Catch-and-Release Fishing Only for White Sturgeon. The recreational fishery for [white sturgeon](#) (*Acipenser transmontanus*) is open from October 1, 2025 through June 30, 2026 in ocean waters, except for the [long-standing area closure](#) between January 1 and March 15 as described in California Code of Regulations Title 14, Section 27.90(i). The daily bag and possession limit for white sturgeon is zero (0) fish. The annual limit is zero (0) sturgeon per person.

White sturgeon greater than 60 inches fork length may not be removed from the water and shall be released immediately. Sturgeon shall not be held out of water suspended by the gills, gill plates, mouth, or solely by the tail, and shall not be dragged across the ground, boat decks, or piers, regardless of size. Lip gripper devices may not be used.

Only one single barbless hook may be used on a line to take sturgeon. The sturgeon must voluntarily take the bait or lure in its mouth. No sturgeon may be taken by trolling, snagging, or by the use of firearms. Sturgeon may not be gaffed, nor shall any person use any type of firearm or snare to take any sturgeon. Any person fishing for sturgeon shall have in their possession a non-transferable Sturgeon Fishing Report Card and complete it in accordance with California Code of Regulations Title 14, Section 27.90 and Section 1.74.

For further information on fishing for white sturgeon, visit the [CDFW website](#).

[Green sturgeon](#) (*Acipenser medirostris*) may not be removed from the water, taken, or possessed at any time. Green sturgeon must be released immediately without being removed from the water.

● Tunas

The recreational fishery for [tunas](#) is open year-round. Refer to [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for bag limits, possession limits, filleting procedures on vessels, and other regulations pertaining to these species.

● Pacific Herring

The recreational fishery for [Pacific herring \(PDF\)](#) (*Clupea pallasii*) is open year-round. Ten gallons of Pacific herring may be taken per day (approximately 100 lb. or 520 fish). No specialized measuring device is required.

● Dungeness Crab

The seasons for [Dungeness crab](#) (*Metacarcinus magister*) are as follows:

Season **north of the Sonoma/Mendocino county line***: Open from November 1, 2025 through July 30, 2026

Season **south of the Sonoma/Mendocino county line***: Open from November 1, 2025 through June 30, 2026

The daily bag limit is 10 crab, and the minimum size limit is 5¾ inches. Sport fishing for Dungeness crab from a registered **commercial** Dungeness crab vessel is allowed as long as commercial and sport fishing activity do not take place on the same day. Dungeness crab may not be taken from San Francisco or San Pablo bays.

Be sure to follow [best practices for using crab traps](#). Crabbers can sign up for crab trap restriction notifications through the [Marine Region News Service](#).

Review [crab measurement methods \(PDF\)](#) and current [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for more Dungeness crab fishing information. For the latest consumption advisories, call the California Department of Public Health's toll-free Shellfish Information Line at (800) 553-4133 or check [CDPH's Shellfish and Seafood Advisories web page](#).

See [additional information](#) about Dungeness crab and other species of crab.

**The Mendocino/Sonoma county line is located near the town of Gualala on the coast.*

● Rock Crab

NOTE: The California Department of Public Health [warns the public to avoid eating rock crab viscera](#) (internal organs, also known as "crab butter" or "guts") from crab taken north of the Sonoma/Mendocino county line* to avoid potential exposure to [domoic acid](#). Crab should be cleaned before cooking. For the latest advisory information, call CDPH's toll-free Shellfish Information Line at (800) 553-4133 or visit CDPH's [Shellfish Advisories web page](#).

The recreational fishery for all rock crab species, including [red crab](#) (*Cancer productus*), [yellow crab](#) (*Metacarcinus anthonyi*) and [brown crab](#) (*Romaleon antennarium*) is open year-round, statewide. The daily bag limit is 35 crab, and the minimum size limit is 4 inches.

Be sure to follow [best practices for using crab traps](#). Crabbers can sign up for crab trap restriction notifications through the [Marine Region News Service](#).

Review [crab measurement methods \(PDF\)](#) and the current [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for more rock crab fishing information.

See [additional information](#) about rock crab and other species of crab.

**The Mendocino/Sonoma county line is located near the town of Gualala on the coast.*

● Mussels

NOTE: The California Department of Public Health is **advising consumers not to eat sports-harvested mussels, clams, whole scallops, or oysters from [Sonoma](#), [Marin or San Mateo county beaches](#)** due to dangerous levels of PSP toxin found in mussels. For the latest advisory information, call CDPH's toll-free Shellfish Information Line at (800) 553-4133 or check CDPH's [recreational bivalve shellfish advisory interactive map](#).

Also, the California Department of Public Health (CDPH) has issued its annual [quarantine on the collection of mussels](#) intended for human consumption. The quarantine is usually in effect from May 1 through October 31 each year. For the latest advisory information, call CDPH's toll-free Shellfish Information Line at (800) 553-4133 or check CDPH's [recreational bivalve shellfish advisory interactive map](#).

The recreational season for [California sea mussel](#) (*Mytilus californianus*) and bay mussel (*Mytilus trossulus*) remains open year-round. Currently, mussels should only be collected for non-consumptive uses (for example, fish bait). The daily bag and possession limit is 10 pounds (in the shell) of California sea mussels and bay mussels in combination. For complete regulation information, see current [ocean sport fishing regulations](#).

Note that the California Department of Public Health monitors and [annually quarantines mussels](#) to prevent human cases of paralytic shellfish poisoning and [domoic acid](#) poisoning; however, warnings advising consumers not to eat recreationally taken shellfish may be issued at any time. The annual quarantine is usually in effect from May through October, and applies only to sport-harvested mussels intended for human consumption. For updated information on warnings, advisories, and quarantines concerning naturally-occurring shellfish toxins, call CDPH's toll-free Shellfish Information Line at (800) 553-4133 or check CDPH's [recreational bivalve shellfish advisory interactive map](#). You can also review CDFW's [Finfish and Shellfish Health Advisories](#) web page.

● Clams

NOTE: The California Department of Public Health is **advising consumers not to eat sports-harvested mussels, clams, whole scallops, or oysters from [Sonoma](#), [Marin or San Mateo county beaches](#)** due to dangerous levels of PSP toxin found in mussels. For the latest advisory information, call CDPH's toll-free Shellfish Information Line at (800) 553-4133 or check CDPH's [recreational bivalve shellfish advisory interactive map](#).

During the open season, clams may be taken from one-half hour before sunrise to one-half hour after sunset. Each person must dig only their own limit of clams. Each person is required to keep a separate container for their clams and not commingle with clams taken by another person. [Hydraulic pumps may not be used to take clams](#), and may not be possessed anywhere clams may be taken. It is unlawful to be on any clam beach with any instrument capable of being used to dig clams during the closed night time hours.

Review [ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for size limits, bag limits, seasons, and other regulations that apply for various species of clam.

● Kelp

The daily bag limit on all [marine aquatic plants](#) for which the take is authorized is 10 pounds wet weight in the aggregate, except that 25 pounds of herring eggs on kelp may be collected. No [eelgrass](#), [surfgrass](#), or [sea palm](#) may be cut or disturbed at any time.

● Other Species

See the [California ocean sport fishing regulations](#) for complete information, including regulations for species not covered here.

Closed Fishing Seasons

● Ocean Salmon

The recreational fishery for [ocean salmon](#) (*Onchorynchus spp.*) is closed. The first spring/summer season opener in this area is scheduled to run from June 27, 2026 through July 22, 2026, or until the harvest guideline is met, whichever is earlier. For further season information, please visit the [Ocean Salmon Fishery Information](#) web page.

● Red Abalone

The recreational fishery for [red abalone](#) (*Haliotis rufescens*) is [closed until at least April 1, 2036](#). For more information about red abalone, visit the [Invertebrate Management Project](#) page.

Additional Resources



[2026 Ocean Sport Fishing Regulations \(PDF\)](#) [↗](#) sport fishing regulations booklet continually updated with the latest sport fishing information

[Ocean Sport Fishing](#) sport fishing regulations, fish identification resources, how-to videos, maps and more



[Ocean Sport Fishing Interactive Map](#) fishing regulations, marine protected areas, groundfish conservation area depth restrictions and more from your mobile device

- [Fish and Game Commission: New and Proposed Regulations](#) [↗](#)
- [Multi-Day Fishing Trip Permit Information](#)
- [Summary of California Ocean Salmon Seasons](#)
- [Summary of Recreational Groundfish Fishing Regulations](#)
- [Cowcod Protections/Groundfish Exclusion Areas](#)
- [California Fishing Passport - Fishing incentive and recognition program](#)

Groundfish - Additional Information

Groundfish Angler and Diver Definitions

- **Boat-based anglers** are fishermen angling from boats or vessels of any size or any other type of floating object, including kayaks and float tubes.
- **Shore-based anglers** are fishermen angling from beaches, banks, piers, jetties, breakwaters, docks, and other manmade objects connected to the shore. No vessel or watercraft (motorized or non-motorized) may be used to assist in taking or possessing [federally managed groundfish species](#) and greenlings of the genus *Hexagrammos*, while angling from shore.
- **Divers** are scuba or free divers with or without spearfishing gear, entering the water either from the shore or from a boat or other floating object. Except for spearfishing gear, all other types of fishing gear are prohibited aboard a vessel or non-motorized watercraft while diving or spearfishing for the purpose of retaining [federally managed groundfish species](#) and greenlings of the genus *Hexagrammos* during a seasonal closure for boat-based anglers.

The recreational fisheries for [federally managed groundfish species](#), greenlings of the genus *Hexagrammos* (and Pacific halibut, which is not a federally managed groundfish species) may close early if

the annual harvest guideline for any one species or group of species is met or is expected to be met prior to the end of the year. Check this website regularly for the latest information.

Federally managed groundfish species that may not be taken and/or possessed in part of a groundfish management area (for example, in a state or federal marine reserve, or other closed area) may be possessed aboard a vessel in transit through the closed area with no fishing gear deployed in the water.

Marine Protected Areas - Additional Information

In addition to the fishing regulations presented here (and in California Code of Regulations and California Fish and Game Code), marine protected area (MPA) regulations may further restrict or prohibit sport fishing within MPAs. [MPA regulations, maps, and coordinates](#) are available on the CDFW website. You can also pick up an MPA brochure at your local CDFW office. Information about California MPAs is also available on the mobile device-friendly [Ocean Sport Fishing and Marine Protected Area Regulations](#) [page](#).

Marine Region (Region 7)

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